

“HOW YOU BULLY A GIRL”:

Sexual Drama and the Negotiation of Gendered Sexuality in High School

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Over the past decade, sexual rumor spreading, slut-shaming, and homophobic labeling have become central examples of bullying among young women. This article examines the role these practices— what adults increasingly call “bullying” and what girls often call “drama”— play in girls’ gendering processes. Through interviews with 54 class and racially diverse late adolescent girls, I explore the content and functions of “sexual drama.” All participants had experiences with this kind of conflict, and nearly a third had been the subject of other girls’ rumors about their own sexual actions and/or orientations. Their accounts indicate that sexual drama offers girls a socially acceptable site for making claims to, and sense of, gendered sexuality in adolescence. While they reproduce inequality through these practices, sexual drama is also a resource for girls—one that is made useful through the institutional constraints of their high schools, which reinforce traditional gender norms and limit sexuality information.

Keywords: *bullying; slut-shaming; homophobia; youth; gender; sexuality; education*

Over the past decade, sexual rumor spreading, slut-shaming, and homophobic labeling have become central examples of bullying among young women. Between 2006 and 2016, the U.S. media covered the suicides of 24 adolescent girls¹ who were the subjects of sexual

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rumors or labeled “sluts,” “whores,” or “lesbians” in the months prior to their deaths. While these tragedies had many contributing factors, they were often reported as examples of “bullycide” (Bazelon 2013), a contemporary “youth crisis” garnering widespread media attention. These cases have placed the intersecting gendered and sexualized dimensions of girls’ conflicts at the forefront of national campaigns against bullying (The Unslut Project 2013), as well as at the center of debates about its criminalization (Marcus 2010). However, while these tragedies made their mark in U.S. consciousness, we empirically know little about the role sexual bullying practices play in girls’ relational lives.

While adults increasingly classify this form of youth conflict as “bullying,” girls are more likely to identify it as “drama”: conflict involving a variety of relationally aggressive practices that vary in severity, often with an audience both live and online (boyd 2014; Marwick and boyd 2014). This article explores girls’ experiences with sexual forms of drama, which involves a constellation of behaviors including sexualized rumor spreading and gossip, slut-shaming, homophobic labeling, and targeted avoidance tactics. Through interviews with 54 class and racially diverse late adolescent girls, I ask what this conflict does: what meanings does it make, what functions does it serve, and why it is useful to young women? I find that while they reproduce inequality through these practices, sexual drama is a resource for girls: one that is valuable for making claims to, and sense of, gendered sexuality within the constraints of high school—an institutional setting that often reinforces traditional gender norms and limits sexuality information.

BULLYING AND GENDERED/SEXUAL HIERARCHIES

Bullying² is both a gendered practice and a gendering process. Contrary to dominant binary ideologies, boys and girls often resort to similar bullying strategies, including insults and rumors (Orpinas, McNicholas, and Nahapetyan 2015; Underwood 2003). However, their practices are routinely characterized as distinct. Boys’ bullying is often described as physical and direct (Wang, Iannotti, and Nansel 2009), while girls’ is often labeled “relational aggression”—an indirect form of conflict including rumor spreading, gossip, name calling, and social exclusion (Brown 2005; Grotper and Crick 1996). These practices help youth negotiate status within their social spheres (Faris and Felmlee 2011, 2014). They also police and produce meanings about gender norms and expectations (Pascoe 2013), informing teens how gender should—and should not—be “done” (West and Zimmerman 1987).

Sexuality plays a significant role in many teens' experiences with bullying (Duncan 1999; Rivers and Duncan 2013). Among boys, the intersection of bullying, sexuality, and gender regulation has been widely documented (Klein 2012; Messerschmidt 2012; Pascoe 2007, 2013). For instance, both Pascoe (2007) and Chambers, Tincknell, and Van Loon (2004) find that homophobic and misogynistic verbal abuse function as mechanisms for boys' collective construction and regulation of masculine gender identities. Girls' bullying practices are also often mediated through discourses about gendered sexuality, including slut slander (Payne 2012) and homophobic slurs (Poteat and Rivers 2010). Girls are also more likely to be targets of bullying when they fail to conform to normative sexual behaviors and feminine gender presentations (Messerschmidt 2012). However, while much has been published recently in the popular press about the intersections of gender and sexuality in girls' experiences with bullying (Cappiello et al. 2015; Lindin 2015; Sales 2016; Tanenbaum 2015), academic studies have largely left unexplored how this conflict contributes to girls' gendering processes.

While bullying is often conceptualized as a "youth problem," its content often reflects attitudes and ideologies pervasive among adults (Bazelon 2013; Klein 2012). Teens' engagement with this content reflects what Corsaro (1992) calls "interpretive reproduction," a means through which children become part of adult culture by creatively appropriating information from the adult world within their peer groups. Thus, rather than blaming them for their participation, it is essential to contextualize teens' bullying practices within broader adult culture and examine closely the institutionally situated meanings they produce and reinforce (Pascoe 2013; Payne and Smith 2013). As Pascoe argues, researchers should be attending "to the way bullying often reflects, reproduces, and prepares young people to accept inequalities embedded in larger social structures" (2013, 9). To do so, we need to pay closer attention to the *content* youth share through these practices. This content illustrates how teens collectively make meaning through conflict—meanings that both reflect and reproduce structural inequalities.

RUMORS, AGENCY, AND GENDER CONSTRAINT

Rumor spreading is the most common form of bullying between girls (Lessne and Cidade 2015). However, we currently know little about the content of girls' rumors and the gossip that surrounds them, and even less about how this content contributes to their constructions of femininity and sexuality. Scholars have long documented the many social functions of

rumor and gossip in everyday life. People's use of rumor and gossip often have agentic, though constraining, qualities: both provide a source for connection and the strengthening of group bonds (G. A. Fine 1985; Gluckman 1963), and a means of projecting a positive self-image by discrediting others (Paine 1967). Both are also mechanisms through which moral standards are established (G. A. Fine 1985) and function as a form of social control by establishing and reinforcing group norms (Eder and Enke 1991).

Rumors and gossip are particularly useful among youth, for whom other resources for attaining social power are limited. As children do not have access to objects or autonomy the way adults do, they develop their own economies within their peer groups (Thorne 1993). These rhetorical strategies have transactional value (Rosnow and Fine 1976) that young people use to develop and reinforce gender ideologies (Chambers, Tincknell, and Van Loon 2004; Eder, Evans, and Parker 1997). Among teens, sharing rumors is a form of currency, a means of exchanging stories for acceptance, connection, and recognition (Marwick and boyd 2014). Yet increasingly, this form of adolescent tender is traded in virtual spaces, as rumors are now spread via text messages and social media. These "networked publics" make rumors more virulent, given their potential to be searchable, replicable, and visible to invisible audiences (boyd 2014). Because of these properties, rumors have the potential to spread further for today's youth than those of earlier eras.

Sexual rumors are nothing if not delicious stories—stories that reflect the institutional contexts of their telling (Plummer 1995). In the accounts that follow, girls' rumors often reflect dominant and negative cultural narratives about women's sexuality that circulate in the media, their schools, and communities. Many studies have captured these narratives and have shown how sexual double standards (Crawford and Popp 2003; Kreager and Staff 2009), along with slut-shaming, homophobic labeling, and other gendered discourses on sexual morality, impact girls' relational lives. These narratives also profoundly shape and constrain girls' sexual subjectivities: their experiences of themselves as sexual beings and their abilities to make sexual choices founded on their entitlement to sexual safety, pleasure, and agency (Martin 1996; Schalet 2009; Tolman 2002).

SLUTS, LESBIANS, AND PEER REGULATION

Rated the worst possible pejorative among girls, and one of the most common among teens (Tanenbaum 2015; Thurlow 2001), the specter of the "slut" has been widely recognized as an organizing principle (Attwood

2007) and a key site where girls engage in boundary-work (Fjaer, Pedersen, and Sandberg 2015; Wilkins 2008). Much like the figure of the "fag" among boys (Pascoe 2007), the "slut" achieves its rhetorical power through abjection (Butler 1990), allowing girls to claim their own normative femininities by repudiating others for their sexual deviance. While boys and men have long used slut talk to discipline girls and women (Cappiello et al. 2015), it is also a discourse used between girls as they negotiate gendered status hierarchies (Armstrong et al. 2014).

Slut-shaming is not only a gendered and sexualized discourse, but one that also reflects existing racialized and classed hierarchies (Bettie 2003; Wilkins 2008; Wilkins and Miller, forthcoming). These hierarchies are reinforced through a history of "controlling images" that position white, middle-class women as sexually "pure" in comparison to low-income whites and women of color (Collins 1990). However, slut-shaming is not solely useful to those most advantaged. Low-income girls and young women of color also employ talk about other women's sexual morality to reject racist and classist sexual stereotypes about their "inherent promiscuity" (Froyum 2010; Garcia 2012), claiming a superior morality to that of "loose" white girls (Das Gupta 1997; Espiritu 2001), or "rich, bitchy sluts" (Armstrong et al. 2014). Importantly, this body of literature shows how judgmental talk about other girls' sexual behavior is *useful* within the context of girls' particular social location.

The "slut" is not the only sexual specter that threatens young women. They are also regulated by, and reinforce social hierarchies through, homophobic talk, judgment, and avoidance tactics (Poteat and Rivers 2010; Renold 2002). For example, Chambers, Tincknell, and Van Loon (2004) find that adolescent girls collectively define femininity by labeling deviant girls as both "sluts" and "lesbians" through gossip rituals, while Hamilton (2007) and Stone and Gorga (2014) find that heterosexual college women distance themselves from lesbian peers. Like slut-shaming, homophobic labeling also functions to shore up race and class boundaries. Froyum (2007) finds that low-income Black girls (and boys) use homophobic strategies to assert their heterosexual superiority to access privilege in ways they otherwise lack. Further, the specters of sluts and lesbians, or what Schippers (2007) calls "pariah femininities," often overlap for young women. In Lees's (1993) study, girls who contest the slut label are often labeled lesbians, while Payne (2010) finds that lesbian adolescents are subjected to *both* homophobic slander and slut-shaming.

Though they often have different outcomes, sexual criteria determining women's morality and worth are persistent in young women's lives,

across social location. These criteria often give the sexual elements of girls' conflict substantial power, practices where stories about "sluts" and "lesbians" function to keep girls from deviating from race, class, gender, and sexual norms. This paper explores the social and institutional mechanisms that make sexual drama *useful* to young women. While some of their experiences clearly constitute bullying, and some do not, their accounts indicate that sexual drama functions along a continuum that girls regularly have to negotiate within their peer groups. Ultimately, this conflict constrains girls' sexual subjectivities while informing their gendering processes as they collectively negotiate gender and sexual norms.

METHODS AND DATA

This analysis draws on 54 semistructured in-depth interviews with cis-gender women, aged 18 to 20, conducted between 2011 and 2014. Participants were recruited from five geographically proximate schools in the Northeast: an elite women's college, an urban and a rural community college, a private urban liberal arts college, and a large public university. Initial participants were sampled through a pilot study at the women's college, while the majority were sampled through introductory courses that fulfilled general education requirements across disciplines. I did not sample for individuals who had been "bullied," but rather I recruited by asking for young women willing to talk about their friendships.

This sampling strategy yielded a diverse pool of participants who had recently attended high school in 13 states across five regions of the United States. Nearly half were working-class or poor and nearly half identified as women of color (see Table 1). As participants were late adolescents, class was assessed based on family of origin, including parents' occupations and highest levels of education (if known). However, as all of these young women were college students at the time of interview, they also were upwardly mobile. Forty-four participants identified as heterosexual, one as queer, two as lesbian, two as asexual, and five as bisexual.

All interviews were conducted on campus and ranged from 45 minutes to three hours. Interviews contained questions about friendships, status, sexuality education, conflict, and schooling. After conducting and transcribing the interviews, I used an inductive process to analyze the data (Wolcott 1994). Upon review, I generated initial themes and identified common patterns that were refined in the analysis and writing process.

TABLE 1: Young Women Interviewed, Aged 18-20

	<i>Asian</i>	<i>Black</i>	<i>Latina</i>	<i>Mixed-Race</i>	<i>White</i>	<i>Total</i>
Upper Middle Class ^a	1	2		3	9	15
Middle Class ^b	1	3		1	10	15
Working Class ^c	1	2	4	1	9	17
Poor ^d			4	1	2	7
Total	3	7	8	6	30	54

a. Participants defined as Upper Middle Class had one or both parents employed in professions that require an advanced degree granting them authority, autonomy, and high wages (e.g., doctors, architects).

b. Participants defined as Middle Class had one or both parents employed in positions that require at least a bachelor's degree also granting them a certain level of authority, yet do not garner higher wages (e.g., social workers, teachers).

c. Participants defined as Working Class had one or both parents employed in blue or pink collar occupations that do not require bachelor's degrees (e.g., construction workers, certified nursing assistants).

d. The parent(s) of participants defined as Poor experienced unstable employment and received federal assistance.

This paper focuses on young women's retrospective accounts of high school, as sexual drama was most prevalent during that period of their lives. The most common form was sexual rumor spreading. In some cases, girls describe drama that circulated less than four months prior to their interview, in others, a few years. While the retrospective nature of the data limits my ability to analyze interactions, their accounts offer insights on the meanings girls made through these experiences. These young women's stories indicate that sexual drama was an instructive element of their adolescence, as they developed attitudes and understandings about gendered sexuality.

"LIKE TRYING TO CATCH SMOKE": THE PERVASIVENESS OF SEXUAL DRAMA

Early in our interview, Gaby,³ a working-class, heterosexual Latina, told me: "That's how you bully a girl, that's how you just get her. You get her by spreading a rumor about her. . . . Trying to stop bullying is like trying to catch smoke with your bare hands." Gaby's adamancy on this point is connected to her personal experience. During the beginning of her junior year of high school, a rumor was spread by a girl friend that Gaby had given a blowjob to a boy in the theater prop room. She recalled, "It

was just horrible, like *horrible*.... to have orally done something in the basement of our school?! Like—I'm a good girl!" Gaby's emphasis on being a "good" girl is indicative of why sexual drama matters to young women. As their narratives will show, these practices are both threatening and useful to girls because they often contain information about the intertwined boundaries of femininity, sexuality, and identity.

Gaby's experience is unfortunately not unique. The young women in this study attended 52 different high schools in five regions of the country, ranging from Catholic, single-sex, Waldorf, charter and tech schools, to magnet math and science academies, elite boarding schools, and urban, suburban, and rural public schools. Some graduating classes were as small as 35, while others came close to a thousand. Across contexts, all women had stories to share about their experiences with sexual drama in their high schools, and nearly a third ($n=16$) had been the subject of a rumor about their own sexual actions and/or orientations. All but one of the girls targeted described significant disruption in their social lives and academic trajectories as a result of the rumors, including depression, changing courses, losing friendships, quitting extra-curricular activities, or leaving school altogether. In all, participants recalled a total of 213 rumors, 201 of which were both sexual and about a girl.⁴ Though not all girls interviewed ended up subjects of a rumor, and many were simply bystanders, their direct and indirect experiences with sexual drama were common, and nearly always perpetrated by girls.

Unlike Gaby, many rejected the notion that they had experienced or participated in "bullying." Instead, more than half ($n = 35$) called these experiences "drama." For example, Helen, a white, upper-middle-class, heterosexual young woman, was often the target of girls' slut rumors both online and live, resulting in isolation and unwanted sexual advances from boys. Yet she did not think she experienced bullying: "I know that it fits [the definition] but like what I see, girls like being mean and talking about other girls, it's girls being girls. I don't see it as bullying, I just see it as drama." This discursive move from "bullying" to "drama" both normalizes girls' behaviors while making them seem inconsequential and unreflective of inequality. Note this rhetorical strategy is also gendered: in their accounts, drama was uniformly described as "a girl thing" or "girls being girls." Yet, while young women's use of this rhetoric reinforces gender norms that undervalue girls (Chesney-Lind and Irwin 2008; Ringrose 2006), its use can also be read agentially. If what they are experiencing is just "drama," then girls are better capable of distancing themselves from being labeled both "bullies" and "victims": adult-defined positionalities (Marwick and boyd 2014) signaling victimization, and

increasingly criminality, that youth are understandably invested in avoiding. Further, young women's insistence that these practices are "girl" behaviors is instructive. If sexual drama is a "girl thing," what is it telling girls about girlhood?

NEGOTIATING WHAT'S "NORMAL"

The content of sexual drama is most visible in young women's accounts of rumors and the gossip that surrounded them. Examined closely, sexual rumors are case studies girls use to negotiate both sexuality and gender norms. As Zoey, a white, upper-middle-class, queer young woman observed, the subjects of rumors "were girls who people knew . . . had done things that weren't considered normal." In these stories, both girls' heterosexual and homosexual activities warranted other girls' gossip and judgment. The 201 sexual rumors participants recalled delineated gendered sexual norms through stories about a girl's: sexual orientation, the sex acts she participates in (e.g., masturbation, oral or anal sex), the context in which she has sex (e.g., while drunk, in public), the sexual partners she has (e.g., their or someone else's partner, authority figures), the quantity of sexual partners she has (e.g., multiple boys, an entire team), or sexual consequences (e.g., abortion, STIs). Notably, these rumors were often unrelated to knowledge of a peer's actual identity or behaviors. In what follows, I offer an analysis of the two central typologies of sexual rumors: lesbian/bisexual ($n = 34$) and slut ($n = 167$) rumors. Throughout, I argue that both types of rumors help young women collectively make meaning about normative sexuality *and* normative femininity.

Lesbian/Bisexual Rumors

Half of the young women described rumors about girls' nonheterosexual actions or orientations ($n = 34$). These rumors often focused on a girl either having too much and/or the wrong kind of desire. For instance, Torielle, a Black, poor, heterosexual young woman told me: "If we heard a rumor that a girl was bisexual in my high school, we considered them a whore. Because we felt like they just . . . wanted both worlds, they were a whore." For Torielle and her friends, bisexual rumors offered sites to make claims about the kind and quantity of desire that is, and is not, normative for girls. Likewise, Lisa, who is white, middle class, and heterosexual, described her friends spreading a rumor about a peer they called "troll girl":

We wouldn't say anything to her but we all talked about it behind her back. . . . We were just saying how gross it was that she was a lesbian . . . about how oh, it's nasty, carpet- whatever that word is? Carpetmuncher? Yeah, you know, like how gross she is.

Lisa recalled how "fun" this gossip was for her friend group at the time. By collectively marking certain sexualities "gross," they implicitly made claims about their own "normative" identities and desires.

Lesbian rumors also were often about the violation of gender presentation norms. As Charlotte, an upper-middle-class, heterosexual young woman explained: "in my town, if you weren't a girlie girl, you were called a lesbian." Girls focused on targeted girls' outward appearance and mannerisms, which were understood to be implicit of their homosexuality. For instance, Mary, a working-class, heterosexual Latina, told me about Jacinda, an openly lesbian peer who was the target of homophobic rumors spread by girls in their high school:

[They] would never have the guts to say anything to her face but I know they would just be like grossed out by it. She didn't look like a girl, she didn't have the feminine ideal, so it wasn't okay. . . . I mean I don't think anyone really like *enjoyed* Jacinda and her outness . . . people didn't even like give [her] the time of day.

According to Mary, the focus on Jacinda was as much about her appearance as it was about her attraction to women. Girls' response was to gossip about and avoid her. Likewise, Toni, a white, poor, lesbian, who was frequently the subject of girls' rumors told me girls talked about her because "I was an outlier in the ways that they felt were most important at the time. . . . I didn't look like them, I didn't dress like them, I didn't have any interests that they did." Toni emphasizes how much her experience of girls' homophobia was about being an "outlier" in both her gender presentation and sexual orientation (see also Horn 2007). In both Toni's and Jacinda's cases, girls' homophobic rumors reinforced to those sharing them the importance of conforming to normative feminine ways of dressing and acting.

These young women's accounts also indicate that girls' negotiation and regulation of gendered sexual norms was consequential to their friendships. Through lesbian/bisexual rumors, girls bonded over their (presumed) heterosexualities while distancing themselves from their peer and from homosexuality in general. For example, Kaya, a mixed-race, upper-middle-class, heterosexual young woman, recalled spreading a rumor

with her girl friends about Jackie, a peer they claimed was having sex with a lesbian teacher. "It was definitely a source of humor for us . . . sometimes it was easy to get caught up with it and make fun of her. It was ridicule definitely . . . it was made to humiliate her, and to make her the butt of jokes." Kaya described this talk as compelling for her friend group, a means of fitting in. She told me, "I guess I really wanted to fit in too . . . it was definitely easier to pick on her and talk about her." While talk about other girls' purported homosexual exploits was described as "fun" for Lisa's friends and a "source of humor" for Kaya's, these narratives served to bond girls while repelling others through the collective marking of gendered sexual boundaries.

Girls at the center of these rumors were well aware of this function. Toni told me girls targeted her "to feel like they were all on the same side about something. That they have something to connect about. To feel a part of something." To make sense of what happened to her, Toni suggested that her peers bonded through the process of drawing boundaries against her. However, this bonding process also isolated targeted girls, with lasting effects. Toni eventually left her high school to pursue a GED, in large part due to girls' homophobic ridicule. While Toni was the only participant to leave school, many targeted girls, regardless of their sexual orientation, described isolation after rumors spread about their sexuality.

This was the case for Charlotte, who is heterosexual but was the subject of a lesbian rumor: "It bothered me. . . . I didn't put myself out there to try and be friends with people. I just kind of like internalized everything people said and just like blocked everyone out." Charlotte intentionally isolated herself after the rumor spread, "blocking everyone out" by smoking pot every day before school. She also described this isolation and fear of girls' judgment lasting into college:

It makes me really uncomfortable like even now . . . like, if you're watching a movie, you're laying on someone . . . I always feel like I can't do that because they would be like, "Charlotte was like cuddling me, she must be a lesbian."

Like Toni, Charlotte also described the lasting impact of homophobic rumors, which not only shaped her relationships with other girls but also her ability to succeed in school. Yet Charlotte's case also captures the regulatory work homophobia performs on heterosexual girls. She concludes, "you'd much rather be a slut than a lesbian in my town."

Ultimately, "lesbian" and "bisexual" rumors function similarly to "slut" rumors. They often operate like magnets: invigorating connections

between some girls, while repelling others through their negotiations of “normative” feminine sexuality. Their content centers not just on *what* a girl does, but *who* she is, and *what it means* to occupy an abject position. It also emphasizes, through repudiation, what it means to be a “normal” girl. However, while girls use lesbian and bisexual rumors to mark and make sense of gendered sexual norms in many of the same ways they do heterosexual rumors, the outcomes are different. Being labeled a slut still offers a girl heterosexual privilege, just not the attendant acceptance or invisibility. Further, lesbian and bisexual rumors were key sites where girls talked about other girls’ *desires*. Ironically, this was largely *not* the case in their stories about “sluts.”

Slut Rumors

All 54 participants recalled some version of a “slut” rumor—rumors that illustrate the boundaries of both femininity and heterosexuality. The young women shared 167 accounts of this form of drama. Slut-shaming and slut rumors were, as Miranda recalled, “the most powerful thing you could say about a girl at the time” because they threatened a girl’s desirability and her femininity. Lisa told me that spreading rumors about girls’ “slutty behavior” is “definitely degrading a woman’s femininity, them being feminine, because if you’re nasty, who wants you?” Here Lisa alludes to the notion that being feminine is about being wanted (by men), not *wanting*. According to her logic, for girls to effectively perform (hetero)normative femininity and not be seen as sluts, they should be desired by boys but not openly desire sex themselves.

However, the subjects of slut rumors were rarely described as agents of their own desires, but rather as passive recipients of boys’. Many girls who ended up in the limelight were those who other girls believed “let boys use” them (see also Wilkins and Miller, forthcoming). Cailyn, who is Black, upper-middle-class, and lesbian, told me that rumors in her high school were “often about girls being complacent to guys.” Likewise, Emma, a white, upper-middle-class, heterosexual young woman, recalled gossiping with friends about Allison, who was often the target of girls’ slut rumors in high school because “she would like be *used* by a lot of guys [pause] for sex. . . . I would have to go pick her up from like guys’ houses because they refused to drive her home once they were like [pause] *done* with her.” Emma’s narrative speaks to the complexities of being a teenage girl navigating unequal power dynamics in sexual encounters with boys, and yet she and her friends did not empathize with Allison. Instead they

judged her "willingness" to "let herself be used." Sharing stories about Allison offered Emma's friend group the ability to collectively claim their own sexual choices as normal, while asserting that they would never be the kind of girls who would "let" themselves be treated badly by boys.

Slut rumors thus emphasize the notion that "normal" heterosexual girls are simultaneously not supposed to show or act on their own desires, nor submit to the desires of boys. Social media provided a broad audience to reinforce this expectation. Davina, a Black, middle-class, heterosexual young woman told me about multiple "exposure" cases on Twitter, when a girl sends a nude picture to a boy that requests it, who subsequently posts the picture publicly. According to Davina, girls often used boys' exposure practices to slut-shame other girls on the social media site, which lead to rumors spreading in her high school:

I remember this one girl, she was arguing [online] with another girl who got exposed and she was like "You're such a whore. Don't forget where you came from." And then she like put the picture in the tweet. Girls, I think, are meaner than guys are.

Here a boy's offense offers an opportunity for girls to shame other girls, both for being sexual and for trusting boys.

In all, 13 young women offered stories of girls using boys' exposure practices to spread sexual rumors and slut-shame their peers, and most were not critical of this practice. For example, Lee, an upper-middle-class, heterosexual, Asian young woman described feeling justified for participating in a rumor about an exposed girl:

You put yourself into the situation . . . you're just asking for it. Like rumors were spread around because . . . you put yourself up there. If you don't want rumors spread around [pause], I mean like that's your own fault.

Like many young women who recalled these cases, Lee is clear that when a girl gets exposed, it is both her fault, and other girls' right, to publicly shame her for her sexual actions and poor judgment.

Slut rumors routinely reinforced gender inequality by positioning girls as culpable, yet passive, actors while rendering boys' choices and actions invisible. As Janelle, a mixed-race, middle-class, heterosexual young woman, explained: "Most rumors had to do with sex. I mean obviously a guy would be involved, but it was like the big thing was that it was the girl." In their accounts, the young women always remembered the girl in

question, but often couldn't remember anything about the boy(s) involved in the story. For example, Carmen and Noelia, both heterosexual, poor, Latinas, told me nearly identical stories from their different high schools about "slutty" girls who were caught "giving someone a blowjob" on school property. The girls' identities were clear—both remembered their names and what happened to them after the rumor spread. But when asked who was receiving oral sex, Noelia was unsure, while Carmen replied with a shrug, "I don't know, just some dude." These responses are indicative of how girls and boys encounter different standards in their experiences of adolescent sexuality (Crawford and Popp 2003). However, they also demonstrate that because of their awareness of these standards, girls are paying attention to the girls—not the boys—in these stories to help make sense of what is and is not permissible sexual behavior for *themselves*.

This was the case for Heather, a white, upper-middle-class, heterosexual young woman, who described a rumor about a girl at a high school scavenger hunt:

On that list it would be things like "have sex with a freshman or get head from a freshman" or like all this nasty stuff, like "have a threesome," like disgusting, disgusting, terrible, horrible, evil things. . . . I was just like, "eeew." . . . But this girl, like, was one of the girl freshmen in the pictures of things that seniors needed [pause] *to do*. . . . Like we did not hesitate to make fun of [her], because I was just like "you literally don't care about yourself, you're so pathetic and it's hilarious."

Heather is making meaning here about *girls'* sexuality. The "we" in the narrative refers to her girl friends, who she recalls collectively making fun of the girl, but notably *not* the boys in the story. The sexual activities are described as "nasty," outside the boundaries of what Heather felt was normative, while the blame rests on the girl, because she "doesn't care" about herself. Meanwhile, Heather ignores the power differentials embedded in the position of being the 14-year-old girl that a group of 17- and 18-year-old boys "needed to do." She then uses gossip to position herself and her friends as the kind of girls who would never put themselves in such a position. Here the rumor makes visible the many inequities young women encounter navigating adolescent heterosexuality, while simultaneously reinforcing them.

Unfortunately, in some cases, boys' "use" of girls in these stories blended into unacknowledged *abuse*. Nine young women recounted "train rumors," where an intoxicated girl allegedly has sex with many boys

sequentially in one setting. For example, Miranda, a white, middle-class, heterosexual young woman, recalled hearing a rumor about two tenth-grade girls who were "wicked drunk" at a party and "had a train run on them" by a group of boys: "I was like, 'Oh boy! Ok. Well, these girls are way into some crazy stuff.' . . . I can't deal with this. Like these girls are sluts." At no point in the interview does Miranda acknowledge that the girls likely could not have given consent that night, let alone to a group of boys. Rather than expressing concern for their well-being, she focuses on what she believes to be their "choices," reinforcing that those are not the kind of choices *she* makes. Miranda was not the only participant to recall a story like this. Mel, who is white, upper-middle-class, and bisexual, recalled a rumor about a girl nicknamed "poopy pants" who got intoxicated at a party and ended up "peeing and pooing and vomiting all over herself" as a boy was having sex with her. Mel told me, in retrospect, "You know in some levels I feel really bad for her. . . . I don't know. It sucks to be called 'poopy pants' in high school. But at the same time, on some level, I want to believe that she deserved it."

In addition to marking the boundaries of what is "normal" feminine sexual behavior, the kind of slut rumors Mel and Miranda tell offer girls an opportunity to distance themselves from the sexual violence that may be taking place in their communities, as well as their own vulnerability. These stories reinforce the normalization of sexual violence among young women (Hlavka 2014) by making these experiences seem commonplace, nonviolent, and commonsensically the girls' fault. If it's a girl's "choice" to "let herself be used" then, the logic goes, she should obviously not be the sort of girl who makes those kinds of choices. If you are the sort of girl who does, you "deserve" the consequences. Because slut rumors always focus on girls' choices, they render *boys'* choices invisible. The normalizing quality of these stories, as well as the naturalized judgments embedded within them, help make existing with the threat of (hetero) sexual violence *within their peer groups* feel less dangerous for young women (see also Armstrong, Hamilton, and Sweeney 2006).

While only some slut rumors alluded to sexual violence, most reinforced the gender inequities that often exist for girls engaged in heterosexual encounters. Notably, these inequities are embedded in the gendered sexual norms girls enforce among themselves. Though some of the inherent cruelty in these stories may be hard to digest, it is important to not blame young women for their engagement with this kind of drama. Girls talk about other girls' sexual "choices" because these conversations offer a crude road map for navigating gendered (hetero)sexuality while avoiding

emotional, social, or physical harm. Ironically, girls were far more likely to receive this kind of information in high school through the rumor mill than through a lesson plan.

FILLING A VOID

As we have seen, talk about *other* girls' sexualities was common in girls' accounts of adolescence. Notably, talk about *their own* was not. For example, Ebony, a Black, middle-class young woman, told me that talk about her and her friends' heterosexual experiences "was sort of like forbidden territory almost in high school." Mel recalled not talking about her bisexual curiosities with her friends because "I felt like it's a really . . . taboo thing." Mariame, a Black, working-class, young woman who identifies as bisexual, remembered about her friends, "We talked about guys a lot. . . . Sex? Not so much. I think that was a little bit uncomfortable, but you did know the girls who were having sex. Like you'll hear rumors." And Kaya told me: "I didn't talk about sex with my friends at all. I remember talking about other girls' sex lives though. Just about different sluts in school." These kinds of responses were surprisingly common among women across race, class, and sexual orientations. While many felt like they couldn't share their personal sexual experiences and curiosities with their peers, sexual drama offered girls a site to *acceptably* talk about sex and sexuality during high school.

In many young women's narratives, talk about personal experiences with sexuality was described as a liability, even among friends. This was true for talk about sexual encounters *and* orientations. For example, Lindsay, who is upper middle class and white, refused to tell her high school friends that she is bisexual: "It would have definitely gotten around . . . it just was never okay to really even question it or to think about it, and certainly not to talk about it . . . cause of like, the whole atmosphere." Likewise, Casey, who is white and poor, told me that she would never share information about her own heterosexual encounters because it was powerful information:

I'm not telling. . . . I don't need the whole school knowing my business. I'm sorry. And you knew that. You tell somebody something, it doesn't matter who that person is, and how best of a friend that person says they are, it's gonna go around. . . . *It's money! It's like money!* [emphasis mine]

It's noteworthy that Casey likens this information to currency (Rosnow and Fine 1976), a commodity to be exchanged for inclusion, attention, or

status. However, this form of "currency" is valuable to young women because of the constraints of the "atmosphere" in which it is exchanged.

This phenomenon has to do with what girls officially learn about gendered sexuality. Priya, an Asian, working-class, heterosexual young woman told me, "Girls aren't supposed to talk about their sexual conquests. They're supposed to be, I don't know, contained. . . . This is just what I've learned." Likewise, Lindsay posited: "There's . . . a taboo about exploring your body and your sexual needs . . . it's all about the men's sexual desire, not about the women's. Especially in high school." Both Lindsay and Priya describe common perceptions about gendered sexuality that circulate among teens and are reinforced in schools. In both comprehensive and abstinence-based sex education classes, sex often *is* all about men's desire and not women's, and also is frequently discussed solely in heterosexual terms (Bay-Cheng 2003; Fields 2008). Girls learn far more about the responsibilities of being an *object* than the experiences of being the *subject* of desire in school settings (M. Fine and McClelland 2006), a phenomenon further reflected in the media and surrounding culture. This was the case for nearly all of the young women in this study. Few reported learning anything about women's sexuality beyond information about STIs and pregnancy. Most recalled learning nothing about nonheterosexual sexualities, and only two reported hearing anything about women's desire or pleasure. Further, multiple young women recalled their teachers telling girls to avoid "acting slutty" and participating in sexual rumors themselves, further reinforcing judgmental gendered messages about girls' sexualities.

Given this context, it is not surprising that the sexual rumor economy is valuable to girls: it fills a void. In the absence of positive and diverse sexuality and gender education, rumors offer information about girls' sexuality in a socially acceptable discursive package. Tales about "the blow job girl," "the slut," "the dyke," "the girl who had a train run on her" are *useful* to girls because they help define their own sexualities as normative in a respectable way. Yet, this is because they have little institutional and social support to do so in other ways. It is not that girls never talked positively about their own sex lives in high school—indeed, some told jovial stories about sharing the details of their virginity loss, coming out, and hookups with their close friends—but most also noted that there was more risk when they did. In sum, girls articulated feeling far more licensed to talk about their sexual standards than their sexual experiences, a message often reinforced through the formal and informal information they received about gendered sexuality at school.

CONCLUSION

Sexual drama flourished in participants' experiences of high school—an institutional setting where girls are given limited sexual information and are rarely supported to talk about their own sexual experiences or curiosities. In this context, sexual rumors offered girls the opportunity to collectively negotiate and make meaning about gendered sexuality. This process likely sounds familiar to gender scholars. Much research on masculinity has shown that bullying offers sites for collective gendered meaning making, as well as opportunities for boys to define their own sexual selves in relation to the ever-fluctuating boundary of what is “normal” (Pascoe 2007, 2013; Rivers and Duncan 2013). As we have seen, girls have similar strategies, with similar outcomes: sexual drama is a vehicle for girls to make claims about their own femininities. However, this process is useful to girls for different reasons, as girls experience more limitations in making claims about desire and sexual experiences in adolescence (Eder, Evans, and Parker 1997; Martin 1996). Thus, in order to make respectable sexual claims about the self, girls are left to make claims about *other* girls' sexualities—naming what *kind* of girl they are by naming what *kind* of girl they are not.

This paradox has to do with constraints on girls' sexual subjectivities. Feminist scholars have documented the many barriers young women experience as they navigate desire and their development of sexual subjectivity, emphasizing the roles that schools, families, the media, and politics play in shaping these constraints (Bell 2013; M. Fine 1988; M. Fine and McClelland 2006; Martin 1996; Schalet 2011; Tolman 2002). My findings indicate that these barriers are also connected to girls' relationships with each other. Collectively, these young women's accounts document how girls' conflicts both constrain and shape their sexual subjectivities and their ability to discuss their own sexual desires and experiences. While structural barriers create the context that makes sexual drama a problematic yet potent resource for young women, we might better support them if we also acknowledge the role that girls themselves play in reinforcing their own “dilemmas of desire” (Tolman 2002). To do so, adults must interrogate and adjust their institutional practices to better support girls in developing healthy sexual subjectivities as well as critical consciousness about gendered sexuality.

This article focused on the commonalities of girls' use of sexual drama in order to explore its functions among them. Across race, class, and sexual orientations, girls told surprisingly similar stories about their experiences

with this kind of conflict in their very different high schools. However, in the interest of space, this paper has not explored the significant distinctions that existed between differently positioned girls in its use and outcomes. As documented by other scholars (Armstrong et al. 2014; Das Gupta 1997; Espiritu 2001; Froyum 2007; Wilkins 2008), girls across positionalities in this study also used slut-shaming, rumors and gossip, and, to a lesser degree, homophobic slander, to shore up classed and racialized boundaries, compete for status, and make claims about themselves in contrast to girls who were not similarly positioned. Further, in some cases, drama appears to be a luxury. For example, some low-income girls and young women of color described resisting involvement in sexual drama in high school because they wanted to avoid being stereotyped or criminalized, or had "bigger things to worry about," including physical and financial insecurity. Meanwhile, privileged girls' accounts often illustrated greater access to drama, as they had more leisure time, and were less concerned about how their behavior would reflect on their families, communities, or academic records. These findings complicate girls' experiences with sexual drama, and I am currently exploring this in depth in a separate paper. Still, the commonalities that exist among this diverse sample of young women illustrate the pervasive role the conflicts described here play in girls' gendering processes across social locations.

While sexual drama was most prevalent in these young women's accounts of high school, sexual judgment still persisted in early adulthood for some. This is not unlike the findings of Armstrong et al. (2014), Hamilton (2007), and Wilkins (2008). Yet, I found that the volume of sexual rumor spreading, reputational slander, and avoidance of girls perceived as doing sexuality "wrong" was markedly less in participants' accounts of college as compared to high school. This finding could be an outcome of the interview process. Participants may have felt compelled to present their current experiences as better than those in the past, sharing accounts of either reformation or liberation in order to claim agency and position themselves in a more positive light.

However, I believe that sexual drama is an institutionally linked phenomenon. Nearly all of the young women narrate a significant change in their and others' engagement with this kind of conflict at college. Across the different colleges they attended, participants described similar shifts in their social landscape: sexual information flows more freely, LGBTQ sexual orientations become less stigmatized, and sex evolves from something only some girls take part in to an activity that all girls are expected to engage. In most of their accounts of college, young women's sexualities

are normalized, rendering conflicts that focus on who and what is sexually “not normal” less useful. While some of the underlying attitudes and judgments persist, the function, outcomes, and social reinforcement of these ideas transformed in similar ways across college contexts. Meanwhile, what their narratives collectively indicate is that U.S. high schools—regardless of size, location, or kind—provided an institutional setting for this kind of conflict to flourish.

Sexual drama illustrates how young women connect through the reproduction of inequality (see also Pascoe 2013). However, rather than pathologizing their behaviors, girls will be better served if we critically acknowledge the contexts in which these behaviors take place. Sexual drama is a powerful social currency that maps onto the closed network structure, limited sex education, and restrictive gender norms that make up many U.S. schools (Bay-Cheng 2003; Eder, Evans, and Parker 1997; Faris and Felmlee 2011; Fields 2008; Klein 2012). In this context, this currency is a resource girls use to compete for status while navigating the gendered peer hierarchies that schools themselves reinforce (Armstrong et al. 2014). Schools are also embedded in a culture where teen girls are hypersexualized in the media (APA 2010), receive limited and constrained sexuality information at home (Elliott 2012; Schalet 2011), often experience unequal power dimensions in heterosexual relationships (Holland et al. 2004), and are subjected to the persistent threat of sexual violence (Hlavka 2014; Phillips 2000). Given these constraints, girls’ use of this kind of conflict is better understood as a *reasonable* reaction to the often sexist, misogynistic, and homophobic culture that surrounds them.

As Gary Alan Fine argues, “A society where rumors spread is characterized by institutional breakdown: either institutions are not communicating, or they are not believed to be providing accurate, fair or necessary information” (2009, 192). When young women are given limited and contradictory information about gendered sexuality, it is no wonder they use sexual drama to make sense of and negotiate its complicated terrain. In lieu of being institutionally and culturally supported in articulating sexual stories that are positive or agentic, girls are left to talk about what they are not supposed to do, what they are not supposed to say, and what “kind of girl” they are not supposed to be. Trying to stop these practices should not be, as Gaby tells us, “like trying to catch smoke.” Yet, given the institutional and cultural contexts girls inhabit, it is currently an uphill battle. Young women have the capacity to share different, positive sexual stories. In order to support them in doing so, adults need to provide them with more information and better templates.

NOTES

1. Cases include July Barrick, Sarah Butler, Amber Caudel, Ashlynn Conner, Amber Cornwell, Amanda Cummings, Rachel Ehmke, Felicia Garcia, Angel Green, Carla Jamerson, Samantha Johnson, Hailee Lamberth, Jessica Laney, Jessie Logan, Gabrielle Molina, Alyssa Morgan, Alexis Pilkington, Phoebe Prince, Meredith Rezak, Ashley Rogers, Rebecca Sedwick, Amanda Todd, Sladjana Vidovic, and Hope Witsell.

2. Definitions of bullying vary. The U.S. Department of Justice assesses bullying by asking "whether another student had made fun of you, called you names, or insulted you; spread rumors about you; threatened you with harm; pushed or shoved you; forced you to do something you did not want to do; excluded you from activities; or destroyed your property" (DeVoe and Bauer 2011). Definitions also often involve repetition (Kann et al. 2014) and an imbalance of power (Olweus 1993). However, scholars have called these qualifiers into question (Faris and Felmlee 2011) and argued that current definitions are too narrow (Finkelhor, Turner, and Hamby 2012).

3. All identifying information has been changed.

4. The 12 unrelated rumors focused on drug use, physical fights, or on a boy's purported homosexuality.

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